

The Recognition Ladder

When someone on your team does great work, the way you recognize it shapes how it's received. Here's a four-rung ladder, ordered from low effort to high effort.

- 1 — Praise privately**
A short message, a quick word in the hallway, a thank-you at the end of a call.
Takes 30 seconds.
- 2 — Praise publicly**
Mention them in a meeting, an email thread, a Teams channel, an all-hands.
Skip this if others contributed comparably - or make sure to name them too.
- 3 — Praise Upward**
Speak well of them to someone whose opinion carries weight: their boss, a senior leader, a client. (*Note: for this to land as a deposit, the team member has to know it happened.*)
- 4 — Entrust with responsibility**
Give them a bigger piece: lead a project, run a meeting, own a deliverable.
Your trust is the highest form of recognition.

Check the fit

Higher rungs aren't always better. An introvert may dread public praise. Someone already overloaded may hear "more responsibility" as punishment. Match the move to the person.